HEALTH SYSTEMS INNOVATION HACKATHON

IMPLEMENTATION GUIDE 2026

HEALTH SYSTEMS INNOVATION LAB
AT HARVARD UNIVERSITY

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About this report

This Handbook on implementing a health systems innovation hackathon is part of a series of the Health System Innovation Lab (HSIL) guidebooks and resources on creating an enabling ecosystem for innovations that could improve health system performance globally. The purpose of this Handbook is to provide hackathon organisers with a step-by-step process of designing, resourcing, and implementing a health systems innovation hackathon globally.

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I. Introduction and context

HSIL Hackathon Overview

Hackathons are marathon hacking events that harness talent from different disciplines, enabling people to collaborate competitively to solve a particular problem by developing a new technology, software, service, process, or institutional arrangement. Hackathon participants work intensively to create a proof of concept with a minimum viable product for a specific problem the Hackathon aims to address. Several institutions organise hackathons each year, providing a platform to address various themes across sectors and industries and enable diverse set of actors from different backgrounds, contexts, and disciplines to participate in the innovation process.

The Harvard Health Systems Innovation Lab (HSIL) Hackathon was launched in 2020 with a single global hub in Boston and roughly 50 participants. This event began as an initiative to bring together students, medical professionals and physicians, and global health leaders to rapidly develop solutions to pressing health-system challenges. Since then, it has evolved into the largest health systems Hackathon in the world. In 2025, the HSIL Hackathon expanded its reach to 19 global hubs with more than 2,500 participants across 5 continents.

HSIL Hackathon Scope

Hackathons differ in their (I) design and organisation; (II) theme and focus; (III) participants; (IV) mentorship; and (V) post-hackathon support — which the organising institutions clearly define. There are several other crucial objectives, including among others, (I) advancing community-building, (II) promoting education and training, (III) acquiring new talent, and (IV) facilitating organisational change, marketing, and communication. The primary objective of a hackathon is to provide an energetic and fast-paced environment to drive targeted innovation – and, in the case of health systems hackathons, accelerate the development of health innovations that create value in health care at the systems level.

The HSIL Hackathon aims to facilitate the development of innovations aimed at strengthening health systems worldwide creating value for money and value for many. The 2026 HSIL Hackathon is centered on the theme of **"Building High-Value Health Systems: Leveraging AI"**.

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II. HSIL Hackathon Collaboration Guidelines

Collaborating Hub Requirements & Expectations

Each collaborating hub plays a critical role in expanding the global reach and impact of the Hackathon. To collaborate as a hub in the HSIL Hackathon, Hubs will need to take on the following responsibilities and activities:

1. **Providing Infrastructure for In-Person Events**
   Hubs must offer suitable physical spaces and necessary infrastructure for local hackathon activities. This includes workspaces, reliable internet connectivity, and audio-visual equipment. Additionally, hubs are required to support virtual attendance for the Hackathon kick-off panel to connect with the main event in Boston.
2. **Attracting Local Innovators**
   Hubs are responsible for engaging local innovators to participate in the hackathon. This involves leveraging local networks, promoting the event actively, and ensuring a diverse mix of students and professionals who are enthusiastic about health system innovation.
3. **Facilitating Local Collaboration and Networking**
   Before the hackathon begins, hubs should foster collaboration among participants. This can include hosting meet-and-greet sessions or virtual forums where participants can connect, share ideas, and begin building collaborative teams. Creating a supportive, interactive local environment is essential for maximizing the hackathon's impact.
4. **Ensuring Seamless Integration with the Main Event**
   Collaborating hubs must coordinate closely with the HSIL team to align schedules, communication channels, and local activities with the main event in Boston. Regular updates, prompt identification of challenges, and participation in knowledge-sharing activities are essential to ensure a consistent and integrated experience for all

Communication Expectations

Effective communication is essential to ensure that all participants in the 2026 Harvard Health Systems Hackathon are engaged, informed, and able to collaborate successfully throughout the event. Clear communication channels allow organizers, participants, judges,

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and mentors to share ideas and resources, clarify requirements for each Hackathon stage, and respond promptly to announcements.

The **HSIL team** will serve as the central point of communication. Communication with hub leads will be coordinated through **email** and **regular Zoom meetings** to answer questions and share key information regarding:

- Hackathon scope and topics, expectations for collaboration, and other key information regarding the event.
- Hackathon process and timelines, including key dates for application opening and closing, any global events ahead of the Hackathon, and Hackathon dates.
- Branding templates, marketing, and communications strategies.
- Relevant organizational guidance.

Collaborating Hub Leads will be responsible for communication within their local hubs and networks, including the following activities:

- Organizing local logistics, including venue arrangements, catering, and AV support as needed.
- Communicating key information and dates to participants, judges, and mentors for the organization of their local event.
- Using marketing and branding guidance shared by HSIL and communicating within their networks to advertise the event and recruit participants and teams.
- Ensuring all local stakeholders are aligned with the Hackathon's overall objectives, timelines, and key dates.

Collaborating Hub Team Component

To successfully implement the HSIL Hackathon, each collaborating hub should establish a Core Organizing Team with clearly defined roles and complementary skills. A typical team consists of five to eight members who collectively manage program coordination, logistics, communications, mentorship, and technical execution. **Individuals within teams may transition between roles before, during, and/or after the Hackathon when needed.** They should be encouraged to suggest ways to enhance the organizing process with the organizing committee.

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Hub Lead is the central figure responsible for providing overall strategic direction. This person serves as the main liaison with the HSIL Core Team, oversees timelines, coordinates team activities, and ensures the hub's operations align with HSIL standards. Strong leadership, project management experience, clear communication, and familiarity with innovation or global health ecosystems are essential qualities for this role.

Communications Lead is responsible for promoting the hackathon within the hub's ecosystem and ensuring visibility across social media, email lists, and institutional channels. They adapt HSIL's approved branding materials for local use and collaborate closely with HSIL's communications team to maintain consistent messaging. This role benefits from strong design skills, effective written and verbal communication, and the ability to engage local audiences.

Logistics lead manages all operational aspects of the hackathon. This includes coordinating the venue or virtual platform arrangements, handling registration and attendance tracking, organizing breakout rooms, and ensuring participants have the tools and support they need. This role requires organizational ability, experience managing events or virtual programs, and the capacity to adapt to changes quickly. This role should coordinate closely with the technical and digital lead to ensure virtual platforms are functioning properly.

Technical and Digital Lead oversees the digital infrastructure required for the hackathon. They manage tools such as Zoom, Slack, Airtable, and submission platforms, and support participants with any technical challenges. This role is best suited for someone comfortable with digital collaboration tools and capable of resolving IT issues efficiently.

External Relations Lead is responsible for strengthening the hub's ecosystem by engaging local networks to recruit mentors, judges, guest speakers, and other key stakeholders who elevate the program's quality. This role ensures access to a diverse pool of experts who support, guide, and evaluate participating teams. Depending on the hub's structure, sponsorship and partnership responsibilities may also fall under this role or be assigned separately. Strong networking abilities, stakeholder management experience, and professionalism in engaging senior leaders are essential for success in this position.

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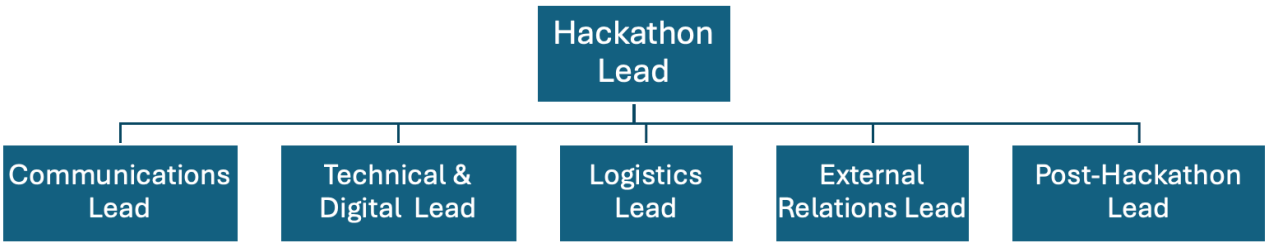
Post-Hackathon Lead is responsible for coordinating all activities that follow the hackathon, ensuring smooth transition of winning teams into the Venture Building Program and supporting continued engagement within the hub. This role oversees communication with selected teams, manages handover processes to HSIL, and ensures all required documentation, updates, and reports are completed on time. The lead also tracks hub outcomes, captures success stories, and maintains relationships with teams as they progress through the venture pipeline. Strong organizational skills, clear communication, and the ability to manage follow-up processes efficiently are essential for this position.

By establishing a Core Organizing Team with these clearly defined roles, each hub ensures effective planning, seamless execution, and strong alignment with HSIL's global vision for the hackathon.



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III. Hackathon Planning

HSIL Hackathon Timeline

Hackathon planning will be launched in September 2025 to adequately prepare for the event. For each Hub interested in participating, the process begins with an initial onboarding call led by the HSIL team to provide an overview of the Hackathon, timeline, and roles and responsibilities for participating Hub.

Following the onboarding call and confirmed interest of the collaborating Hub, a focal point for the Hub will be identified for subsequent communication. The HSIL organizing team and the Hub focal point will schedule regular meetings to share progress updates and to discuss any questions. The Hub team will launch the planning for their local Hackathon event, including logistics related to the venue, and engagement within their networks to engage with potentially interested students or professionals.

Figure 1 outlines the key stages of the Hackathon including the application period, The HSIL Collaborative Hub Program, and the Hackathon main event which feeds into Bootcamps I & II, and the Venture Building Program. **Appendix 1** outlines essential tasks and recommended timeframes, grouped by the key roles within the Hub Team Component.

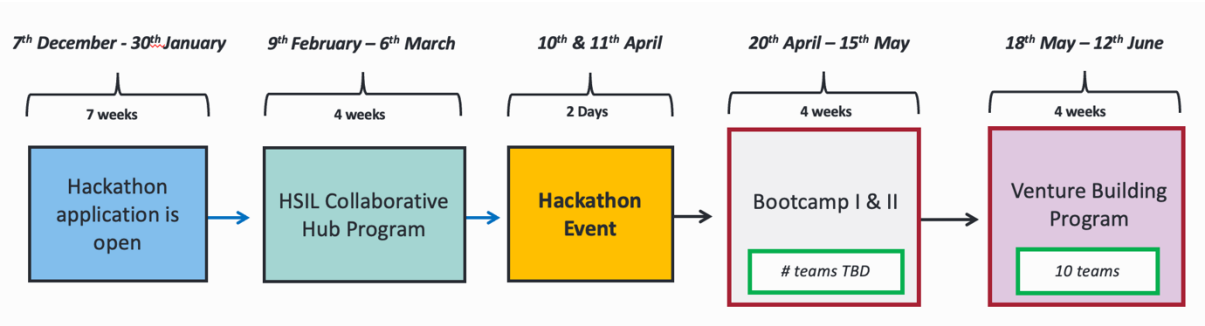

Figure 1 – HSIL 2026 Hackathon Timeline

Hackathon Application Process

Applications for the hackathon are scheduled to open on December 7th through an efficient centralised system managed by the HSIL team in collaboration with a representative from

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each hub. The application window will remain open for eight weeks, allowing sufficient time for the call to reach all interested participants.

During the registration period, the HSIL team and each hub lead will monitor submissions closely to ensure that registrations do not exceed hub capacity. Once a hub reaches its maximum capacity, the application portal for that specific hub will be closed.

Pre-Hackathon Participant Communication

After the application period, hubs will have two weeks to review submissions and communicate outcomes to applicants. Accepted participants will then be migrated to the HSIL Hackathon Slack workspace to support team formation and ongoing communication.

HSIL Collaborative Hub Program

In the four weeks leading up to the Hackathon, several global pre-hackathon events will take place. Collaborating hubs are strongly encouraged to host local preparatory events to foster collaboration, strengthen engagement, and ensure participants are well-prepared for the main hackathon.

Identifying Mentors & Judges

Mentors and judges are essential to the quality of ventures and the overall success of the hackathon. The External Relations role within each collaborating Hub is responsible for engaging experienced professionals across diverse fields—including health systems, entrepreneurship, clinical practice, technology, and industry—to provide expert guidance, balanced evaluation, and practical feedback. Their involvement strengthens team learning and ensures that solutions are rigorous, feasible, and impactful.

Mentors and Judges must be present and available during the Hackathon Event. Mentors will be responsible for providing support and feedback to the venture teams during the pitch development and practice sessions of the Hackathon. Judges will be responsible for scoring pitches against predefined criteria and identifying winning teams.

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Hackathon Event Logistics

Collaborating hubs are responsible for coordinating facilities and supplies required for the successful execution of their local Hackathon event. This includes venue specifications and reservations, catering, stationery, swag, and other hardware needed on the day of the event. The team must ensure availability of all stationery necessary for in-person participation, such as flipcharts, post-its, markers, pens, and other equipment such as extension cords that will enable the smooth organisation of the event.

Venue

For in-person Hackathons, Hubs should identify and reserve a well-equipped venue that can accommodate the expected number of participants. This venue should have comfortable furniture, proper lighting and ventilation, washroom facilities, and an efficient rubbish disposal system. The team should book the venue early to ensure availability during the Hackathon dates.

Catering

Options should be outlined 1-2 months prior to the event and finalised at least three weeks before the event. Catering orders should take into account the number of participants, as well as common dietary restrictions.

Hardware & Software

Specific needs will vary across hackathons, particularly in the quantities required. The following are ideal: (Laptop computer for each team member, Projectors, Microphones, Storage Device (e.g., USB stick), Power extension cords, etc. Software required for successful implementation include Licensed Zoom account with a Webinar feature, Slack channel, WhatsApp, Microsoft office, Social Media Accounts, Airtable.

Materials

Other materials required for Hackathon participants on the day of the event include flipcharts, post-it pads, pens, pencils, markers, erasers, table covers, and white sheets of paper.

Personnel and Staffing Requirements

On the day of the event, a team from the Hub must be on-site to set up the venue with the right equipment, and proper arrangement of furniture and stationery. They must also ensure

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that all required materials are delivered and ready to use. They will provide refreshments and guide participants around the venue. While we recommend that members of the organising team possess a core skill, we recognized that some team members may need further training to enhance their outputs. It is the responsibility of the core Hub team to ensure all team members develop the necessary skills to perform their tasks using this guidebook and other resources. These developed skills assist them in careers in health systems innovation.

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IV. Hackathon Event Implementation

The HSIL Hackathon will be held on April 10th and 11th, 2026 in the Boston Hubs and all global participating. This section outlines the key activities and the sequence of events that all HSIL Hackathon events should follow.

Due to the fast-paced nature of the event, the organisers must finalize a two-day agenda ahead of time. Schedule development is a collaborative effort that requires input from all sub-teams. A proposed Hackathon schedule is provided in Appendix 2. Organisers may develop a playbook to ensure that each of the teams, including participants, understands what they need to be doing during each hackathon session (Appendix 3).

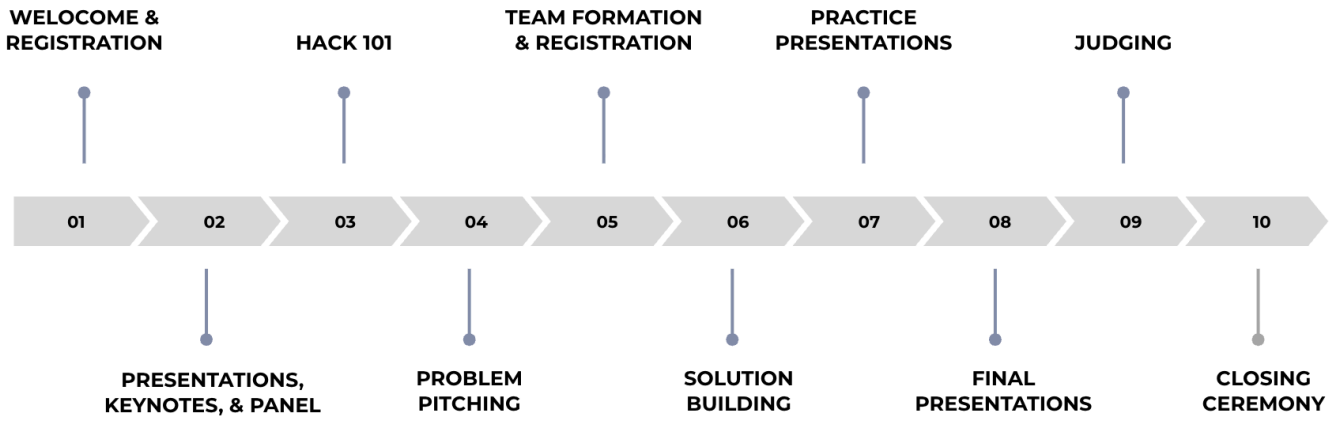

Figure 3. Major checkpoints in the hackathon process

Registration

Registration opens prior to the official start of the event to capture details of all participants, mentors, judges, and guests. This process is a critical step to ensure that all accepted applicants are accurately recorded and fully represented in the event database.

Welcome Address

A brief welcome note marks the official launch of the event to set in motion the hackathon process and is given by the Hub lead.

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Presentations, keynotes, and panels

A series of keynote presentations and panel discussions set the stage for the Hackathon by analysing the problem, exploring the innovation ecosystem, and highlighting key contextual and health system considerations. These sessions are designed to inspire participants and foster active engagement. Panels are encouraged to be as inclusive and diverse as possible, bringing together stakeholders from multiple sectors and perspectives to stimulate innovative solutions to both local and global health system challenges.

Side events

Depending on resource availability, the team may organise side events to explore specific knowledge areas, skills, or networking that may assist participants in developing their solutions. Side events may include quick training on coding, data analysis, and health systems. The Hub organising team will provide announcements to remind participants of side events per the hackathon schedule.

Hack 101

A core team member of the Hub team gives a brief introduction to the Hackathon process, which provides an overview of the expectations for each session of the schedule. The team member introduces all organizing team members to ensure participants know whom to approach for specific challenges and concerns.

Problem pitching

The organizing Hub team will create a concise 3-4 slide deck. Using this deck, an expert intimately involved in the problem or desired solution of interest presents an overview of the problem statement. The problem statement consists of the problem analysis, innovation ecosystem, major stakeholders influencing adoption, institutional setting, and broad context.

Team formation, registration, and mentorship

The organizing Hub team coordinates and finalises team formation and registration which may be voluntary or involuntary. The team further coordinates mentorship sessions where mentors follow up with all teams to ensure they are on track and progressing in the right direction.

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Solution Building

During the solution-building phase, teams break into designated spaces based on available resources to further develop their ideas. This is a rigorous and collaborative process that involves extensive research, brainstorming, and iterative design.
Mentors play a key role during this stage, providing technical guidance, strategic feedback, and practical insights to help teams refine their solutions into viable concepts ready for presentation and potential incubation.

Practice presentations

The organizing Hub team will connect with teams to practice their presentations pitches, with targeted feedback before final pitch submissions and presentation to the entire Hackathon group.

Final presentations and Judging

The organizing Hub team will collect all final presentations and collaborate with the judging panel to determine a randomized order for team pitches. Each team will present their ideas before a live audience under a specified time during (i.e. 3 minutes) followed with Q&A (i.e. 5 minutes). Judging will be conducted using standardized evaluation rubric (Appendix 4)., which is shared with the judges and made available to all teams to ensure fairness and transparency.

Awards and closing ceremony

After the judges have selected the winning teams, the host will present prizes for winner, first runner-up, second runner-up, and other recognitions (subject to availability), marking the official conclusion of the hackathon. The closing ceremony will include final remarks from organizers, partners, and mentors, highlighting key achievements and next steps for participating teams.

The event concludes with a group photograph to commemorate the hackathon year, followed by networking and exchange of contacts to foster future collaborations among participants, mentors, and partners.

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V. Post-Hackathon Activities: Bootcamps & Venture Building Program

The Venture Building Program (VBP) is a global, fully virtual innovation program that convenes all winning teams nominated by their respective hubs to advance their solutions under a rigorous, curated framework led by HSIL. The program runs for eight weeks, structured into three progressive stages: Bootcamp I, Bootcamp II, and the Venture Building Immersion.

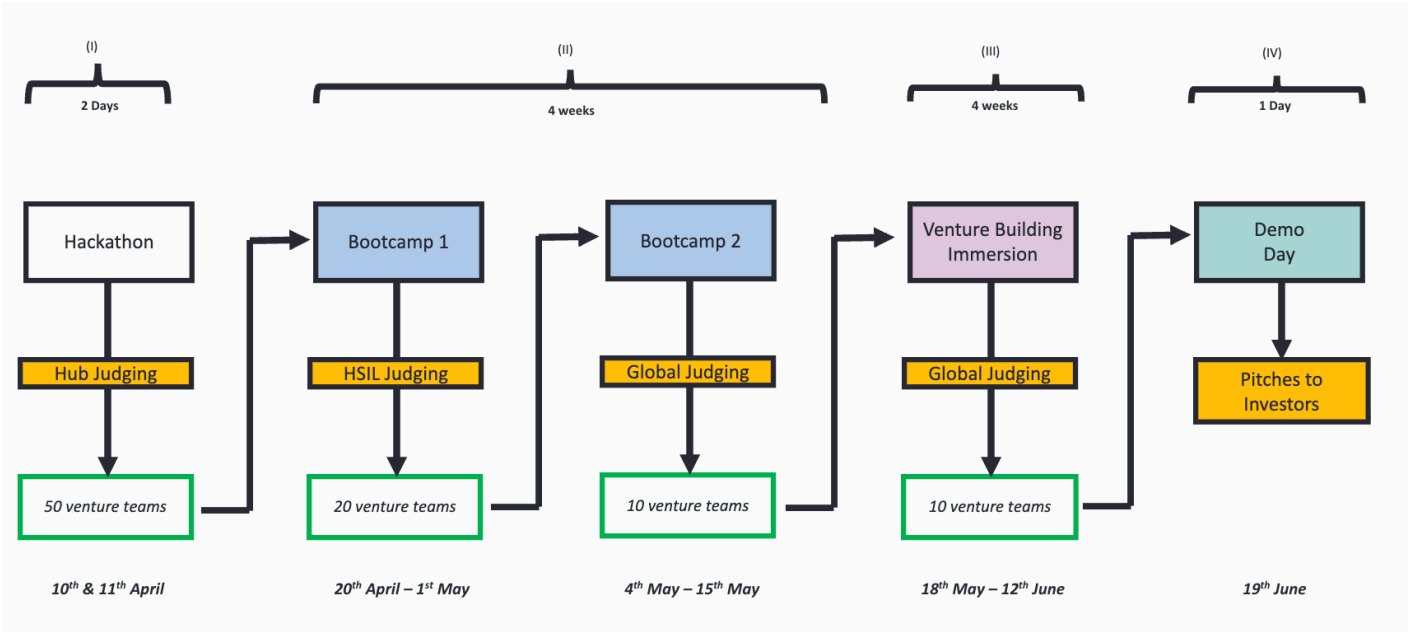

Figure 2: 2026 Post-Hackathon Bootcamp & Venture Building Program Timeline

Bootcamp I

Bootcamp I is a blend of live sessions and pre-recorded modules designed to build community and help innovators refine their ideas. During this two-week phase, teams receive 1:1 mentorship, engage in curated learning sessions, and strengthen the foundations of their solutions. The stage concludes with all venture teams pitching to a panel of Harvard judges.

Bootcamp II

Bootcamp II is an additional two-week deep dive for teams that advance from the first judging round. In this stage, selected ventures continue sharpening their solutions, receive

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tailored 1:1 mentorship, and refine their value propositions, business models, and technical approaches. The phase ends with a global pitch session before a Global panel of expert judges.

Venture Building Immersion

The Venture Building Immersion is an intensive final stage for teams that successfully progressed from Bootcamp II. Over this four-week period, ventures are nurtured and stress-tested to ensure their solutions are technically, operationally, and financially robust. Teams prepare functional demos, validate their implementation pathways, and finalize their narratives. The immersion culminates in Demo Day, the program's penultimate event, where teams pitch to investors, VCs, ecosystem leaders, and the global innovation community.

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VI. Appendix

Appendix 1. Implementation Schedule

Activity	Suggested Timeline	Responsible	Complete (Y/N)
Role 1: Collaborating Hub Lead			
Oversee project planning and implementation & adaptation of materials	6 months before Hackathon		
Recruit, train, and resource organising team	5 months before Hackathon		
Engage and consult external sponsors	5 months before Hackathon		
Coordinate engagement with keynote speakers or panellists	4 months before Hackathon		
Organize a series of pre-hackathon local	3 months before Hackathon		
Finalise Hackathon schedule	1 month before Hackathon		
The Hackathon lead will join the judging deliberations, present the final judging scoresheet and support the judging process	Day of Hackathon		
Role 2: Communications			
Develop marketing and communication strategy	6 months before Hackathon		
Design Social Media communication materials: - Event poster - Poster of keynote speakers/panellists - Social Toolkit for Days 1 and 2 of the Hackathon - Emails to targeted individuals, listservs and institutions	6 months before Hackathon		
Post materials on Instagram, Twitter, and notice boards and share all emails	5 months before Hackathon and regularly thereafter		
Send out a call for mentors and volunteers	5 months before Hackathon		
Develop communication channel briefing note	4 months before hackathon		
Introduce participants to communication channels and begin engagement	1 month before Hackathon		
Role 3: Logistics Lead			
Book venue	5 months before Hackathon		
Organise catering	4 months before Hackathon		

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Coordinate in-person attendance	2 months before and during Hackathon		
Purchase and ensure delivery of all stationery and other materials	2 months before Hackathon		
Share participant handbook	2 months before Hackathon		
Develop master slide deck	1 month before Hackathon		
Collect and bring all stationary, materials and equipment to the venue	Day before hackathon		
Coordinate/Facilitate agenda during the Hackathon, including practice pitches	Day of Hackathon		
Rotate through teams to check-in, note-taking to record innovation processes	Day of Hackathon		
Follow up with teams to submit their final presentations for Judging	Day of Hackathon		
Collect judging forms from all judges	Day of Hackathon		
Tally up scores for each judge and develop a final judge scoring sheet with suggested winners and present to the leadership team 20 mins after final judging	Day of Hackathon		
Role 3: Technical and Digital Lead			
Develop and share registration survey	5 months before Hackathon		
Monitor registrations numbers and present updated numbers in the form of a bar graph and pie chart to be shared with team and external partners	Daily after applications open		
Review and approve applications and organise applicants into teams	3 months before Hackathon		
Coordinate virtual attendance – set up zoom links	3 months before Hackathon		
Confirm internet connectivity and share details via communication channel	1 week before Hackathon		
Ensure availability of functioning projectors, computers, mics, and power cords.	1 week before Hackathon		
Coordinate interactions and communication on Slack	Day of Hackathon		
Coordinate photography and video	Day of Hackathon		
Provide technical/digital support to ensure all AV needs are met	Day of Hackathon		
Role 4: External Relations			
Initiate partnership and sponsorship outreach	6 months before Hackathon		
Confirm mentors, judges, and potential speakers	3-4 Months before Hackathon		
Share event details, logistics, and media guidelines with participants	2 weeks before Hackathon		
Coordinate networking event	Day of Hackathon		

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Send appreciation letters and share event highlights or reports.	1 week after Hackathon		
Role 5: Post Hackathon			
Send post-event survey to all participants	1 week after Hackathon		
Develop and send certificates to all Participants			
Contact winning teams to enter the HSIL incubation program			
Put winning teams in contact with Sponsors			
Engage teams to develop venture plans and implementation strategy	2 months after Hackathon		
Provide a report outlining all ventures			
Engage teams to refine Venture Proposals			
Develop financing strategy			
Prepare and share venture outcomes report with key stakeholders and sponsors	4 months after Hackathon		
Work with venture teams to develop case studies after completing the innovation pipeline			
Convene key stakeholders to review lessons learned and guide planning for the next hackathon			

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Appendix 2. Sample of Hackathon schedule

Day 1

Time	Title	Speaker	Session Overview
5 minutes	Welcome and introduction		
30 minutes	Keynotes (Optional)		
25 minutes	Moderated panel discussion and Q&A		
15 minutes	BREAK	All	Tea/Coffee Break
15 minutes	Hack 101		
1 hour	Problem Pitching		
1 hour	Team Formation	All teams	Team formation is confirmed
	Team Registration Due	All teams	Final team names are determined
30 minutes	BREAK	All	Lunch/dinner break
2 hours	Focused mentorship begins	Mentors + teams	Participants sign up for 15-minute consultation sessions with mentors
	Focused mentorship ends	All teams	Teams continue working on their innovations

Day 2

Time	Title	Speaker	Session Overview
5 minutes	Welcome & Day 1 Recap		
25 minutes	Moderated panel discussion and Q&A: Select challenges requiring digital innovation		
1 hour	Focused mentoring	Mentors & teams	Participants to sign up with mentors at least once on Day 2 for feedback and practice
1 hour	Practice presentations	All teams	

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30 minutes	BREAK	All	
20 minutes	Final pitches	All teams	Final presentations from all teams Each presents a 2-minute pitch followed by 3 mins Q&A
30 minutes	Judge deliberations		Judges deliberate and assess pitches according to predefined criteria.
	Awards and closing	All	Winners are announced, and awards presented

Appendix 3: Hackathon playbook

Appendix 4. Sample of judging rubric

Judging criterion	Points
Impact	5
Innovation	5
Business model	5
Presentation	5
Total	20

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